Respond to a new lead within one hour

Speed is the strongest signal that you are easy to work with. This process makes sure every new inquiry gets a warm, personal reply within one hour during [business hours] and a clear next step.

OWNER Owner or Assistant

TOOLS Email; Phone or text; CRM or contact list; Calendar; Notifications

BE READY TO RESPOND

- [ ] Turn on notifications for new inquiries. Send form submissions, messages, and calls to [your phone or email] so you see them quickly.
- [ ] Save a reply template for each common inquiry. Write short, warm drafts with blanks for the name and question, and keep them where you can reach them fast.
- [ ] Decide who responds and when. Name a backup for [times you are unavailable] so no lead waits more than one hour during business hours.

REPLY WITHIN THE HOUR

- [ ] Read the whole inquiry before you reply. Note their name, what they asked, and anything urgent or unclear.
- [ ] Use their name and answer their actual question first. Then say one sentence about how you can help and what happens next.
- [ ] Offer one clear next step. Share [your booking link] for a call, or ask one simple question if you need more detail.
- [ ] Reply in the same way they contacted you. Answer email with email, and use text or a call if they gave a phone number and asked for that.
- [ ] Check your message before sending. Confirm spelling, the name, the link, and that the tone is friendly and not pushy.

FOLLOW UP AND RECORD

- [ ] Add the lead to your CRM or contact list right away. Record name, contact details, source, date, and what they asked for.
- [ ] Set a follow-up reminder for [two business days]. If they have not replied, send a short, kind check-in with the same link.
- [ ] Continue [three follow-ups over two weeks], then stop. After that, move them to a longer-term list and tell them they are welcome to reach out later.
- [ ] Review your response times weekly. Done looks like every lead replied to within an hour and logged with a next action.

Follow up with leads who have gone quiet

Leads often go quiet because life got busy, not because they said no. This process gives every quiet lead a short, respectful follow-up sequence and a clear final status, so no opportunity is left sitting without a decision.

OWNER Owner
TOOLS CRM or contact list; Email; Calendar; Phone or text

FIND WHO HAS GONE QUIET

- [ ] Filter your CRM or contact list for leads with no reply in [7] days. Include anyone who had a call, proposal or quote but did not answer your last message.
- [ ] Sort the list from warmest to coldest. Put people who asked for pricing or booked a call at the top, and general inquiries at the bottom.
- [ ] Reread the last conversation with each lead before you write. Note what they asked for, what worried them, and anything you promised to send.
- [ ] Remove anyone who said no, asked you to stop, or has already bought. Following up with them damages trust.

SEND THE FOLLOW-UP SEQUENCE

- [ ] Send a short check-in on day [7]. Mention something specific from your last conversation and ask one easy question, such as 'Is this still something you want to move on?'
- [ ] Send a helpful message on day [14]. Share one useful item, such as [a case study, short guide or answer to their question], with no request attached.
- [ ] Send a direct message on day [21]. Offer two clear options: book a call at [your booking link], or tell you the timing is not right.
- [ ] Try a second channel if email gets no reply. A short text or phone call from [your phone number] works well, but only use channels the lead has already used with you.
- [ ] Log every message in your CRM the same day. Record the date, the channel and what you said so you never repeat yourself.

CLOSE THE LOOP

- [ ] Send a final polite note on day [28]. Say you will stop reaching out and that they can contact you any time at [your email].
- [ ] Move non-responders to a 'Not now' list. Add them to [your newsletter or update list] only if they agreed to receive it.
- [ ] Set a reminder to review the 'Not now' list in [90] days. A reply then often arrives when circumstances have changed.
- [ ] Check that every quiet lead has a logged next step, a reminder or a closed status. Done means nothing is left without a decision.

Onboard a new client

A smooth start builds trust and sets the tone for the whole engagement. This process takes a new client from payment to a well-prepared first session, with every form, date and expectation in place.

OWNER Owner
TOOLS Email; Calendar; CRM or contact list; Forms; Notes document

RIGHT AFTER THEY SAY YES

- [ ] Send a welcome message within [one business day] of payment. Thank them, confirm what they bought and list the steps before the first session.
- [ ] Send your intake form and agreement. Use [your intake form link] and ask for them back within [3 business days].
- [ ] Send your scheduling link and ask them to book the first session. Include [your booking link] and a date range, such as within the next [10] days.
- [ ] Add them to your CRM and mark the stage 'Onboarding'. Record the start date, offer, payment status and which forms are outstanding.

PREPARE FOR THE FIRST SESSION

- [ ] Check that the intake form and signed agreement are back [2 days] before the session. If not, send a friendly reminder with the links again.
- [ ] Read their answers and your sales call notes. Write down three things you want to understand better.
- [ ] Create their client folder and notes document. Use your [folder template] so every client is set up the same way.
- [ ] Prepare your session plan. Decide the goals, your key questions and the agenda for the first [60] minutes.
- [ ] Send a reminder [24 hours] before the session. Include the time, how to join and anything they should bring.

RUN THE FIRST SESSION AND FOLLOW UP

- [ ] Open the session by confirming their goals and what success looks like in [30 or 90] days. Write down their own words.
- [ ] Agree on one or two actions they will take before the next session. Put a date on each.
- [ ] Send a recap within [24 hours] of the session. Include what you agreed, their actions and the date of the next session.
- [ ] Book the next session before you end the call, or send the link the same day.
- [ ] Update your CRM stage to 'Active client'. Done means the client has had their first session and knows exactly what comes next.

Month-end bookkeeping and review

Keeps your books accurate and current so you always know what you earned, spent and owe. Done when every transaction is categorized, each account matches its statement, and you have reviewed a one-page summary for the month.

OWNER Owner

TOOLS Accounting tool or spreadsheet; Bank and card statements; Calendar; Cloud storage

GATHER THE MONTH'S RECORDS

- [ ] Block time on your calendar. Book [90 minutes] on the [first Friday] of each month so this happens on schedule instead of whenever you remember.
- [ ] Pull your statements. Download the month's statements for [business checking account], [business credit card] and [payment processor] so you can match them to your books.
- [ ] Collect your receipts. Put paper and emailed receipts for the month in one folder named [YYYY-MM]. Anything without a receipt goes on a short find-later list.

RECORD AND RECONCILE

- [ ] Categorize every transaction. Step through the month in your [accounting tool or spreadsheet] and assign each one a category. Mark anything unsure as 'ask my [accountant]' rather than guessing.
- [ ] Match income to invoices. Check that each deposit lines up with a paid invoice and mark the invoice paid. List any money received with no invoice behind it.
- [ ] Reconcile each account. Compare the ending balance in your books to the statement balance. Chase any difference until it is zero or explained in a written note.
- [ ] Review recurring charges. Confirm each subscription is recorded and still needed, and cancel anything you no longer use.
- [ ] Set aside tax and owner pay. Move [amount or percentage your accountant recommends] into your tax savings account and record your owner pay for the month.

REVIEW THE NUMBERS

- [ ] Run your summary reports. Open your profit and loss report and cash balance for the month and save a PDF copy in [your records folder].
- [ ] Compare to last month and your target. Note income, your largest expense categories and profit. Write one sentence on anything that moved more than [10 percent].
- [ ] List what is owed. Write down unpaid client invoices and unpaid bills with due dates, and decide who you will follow up with this week.

CLOSE THE MONTH

- [ ] Record your next actions. Write down [up to three] decisions or follow-ups from the review and put a date for each on your calendar.
- [ ] Mark the month closed. Note the date you finished in [your books log] and lock or flag the month so old entries are not changed by accident. Done looks like zero uncategorized items and balances that match.

Ask for a referral

Turns happy clients into introductions to people who need your help, in a way that feels natural and easy. Done when the ask is sent, the response is tracked, and the person has been thanked.

OWNER Owner
TOOLS Email; CRM or contact list; Calendar; Phone

CHOOSE THE PERSON AND THE MOMENT

- [ ] List [5 to 10] people to ask. Pick clients who have had great results, sent a compliment or finished an engagement.
- [ ] Wait for a good moment. The best time is right after a win, a thank-you note or a milestone, when the value is fresh in their mind.
- [ ] Decide exactly what you are asking for. Name the kind of person you want to meet, such as [your ideal client description], rather than asking for anyone.

MAKE THE ASK

- [ ] Write a short, specific message. Thank them, name the result they got, and ask whether they know [type of person] who could use [your service].
- [ ] Make it easy to pass along. Include a two-sentence blurb they can forward and [your booking link or contact details].
- [ ] Send it personally. Use a direct email or a call, one person at a time, and not a mass message.
- [ ] Give an easy way to say no. Add a line such as 'No pressure at all if nobody comes to mind.'

FOLLOW THROUGH

- [ ] Thank them within [one business day] of any reply, even when the answer is no.
- [ ] Respond to the introduced person within [one business day]. Mention who suggested you and offer [a first call or free resource].
- [ ] Update the referrer. Tell them how it went within [two weeks], without sharing private details of the new person.
- [ ] Log the referral. Record who referred whom in your [CRM or tracking sheet] so you can see where new clients come from.

CLOSE THE LOOP

- [ ] Send one gentle nudge after [7 days] if there was no reply, then pause asking that person for [90 days].
- [ ] Check the done list. Done looks like the ask sent, the reply tracked, the thank-you delivered and the next ask date noted.

Protect Your Business Check

Protection is cheapest before you need it. Mark where you stand on each one.

ITEM	HAVE	NEED	N/A
Business entity formed	☐	☐	☐
Separate business bank account	☐	☐	☐
Client agreement	☐	☐	☐
Contractor agreements	☐	☐	☐
Liability insurance	☐	☐	☐
Quarterly taxes scheduled	☐	☐	☐
Privacy policy on your website	☐	☐	☐
Email consent and unsubscribe	☐	☐	☐
Access and succession plan: who could run things if you could not	☐	☐	☐

THE ONE ITEM I WILL TAKE CARE OF FIRST, AND BY WHEN

> General guidance only, not legal advice. Check anything you are unsure of with your attorney or accountant.